

Laps Not Apps

A cozy read-aloud made for **Maya**



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A Play Before Pixels read-aloud



Laps Not Apps

Personalized edition. Each copy is printed on demand for one reader.

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Read together, and keep books away from mouths. The lap games in this book are for play and connection, always with an adult close by. This book is general parent education. It is not medical or developmental advice.

Illustrations are flat vector art. Text is set in Fredoka and Nunito Sans, with titles in Bricolage Grotesque.

For
Maya

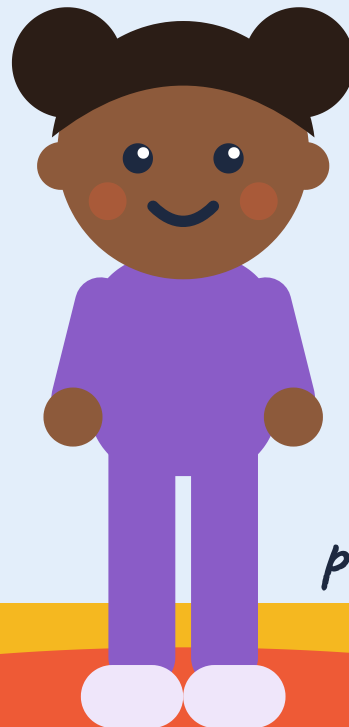
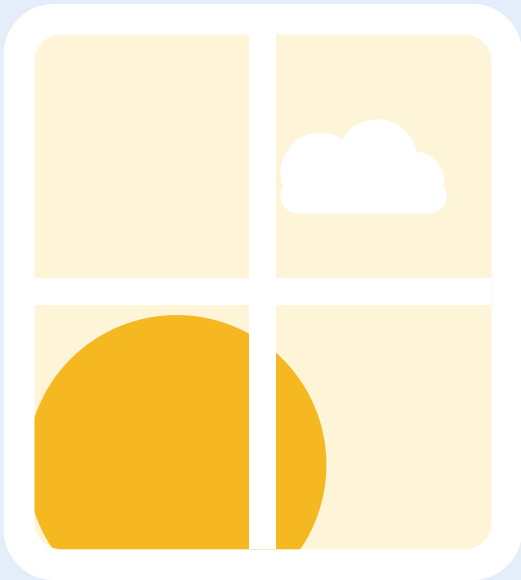
May every day bring you a lap, a story and a song.
We love you to the moon and back.

With love from
Aunt Lily

Baby shower · October 2026



**The sun peeks in early.
It's morning! Hooray!
I pad down the hall
to find laps for the day.**

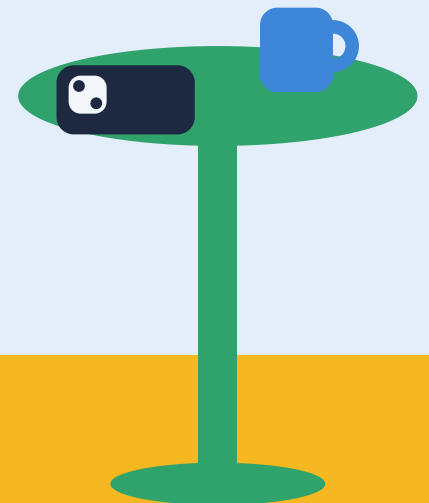


pad, pad, pad...

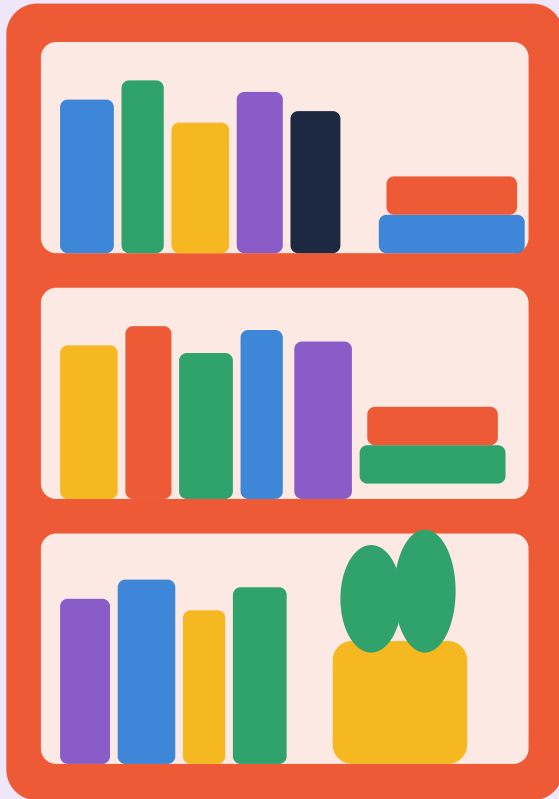
There's Dad in the armchair,
his phone facing down.

“Hop up here, **Maya**—
it's the best seat in town!”

Lap talk Pat your lap and wait. Let your little one choose to climb up—then say hello like they just arrived.



Then Grandma rolls in
with a book on her knee.
“A seat saved for **Maya!**
Come and read it with me.”



**Her lap is a lap
with the very best wheels.
We read about bears
and a boat full of seals.**

Lap talk Before you turn the page, pause and count to five in your head. Let them point, pat or name what they see first.



She reads with a ROAR,
and she reads with a squeak,
a mouse-sized small whisper,
a kiss on my cheek.

ROAR!

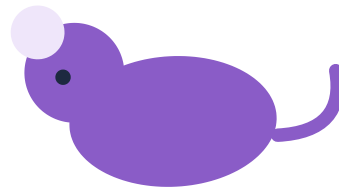
squeak!
shhh...



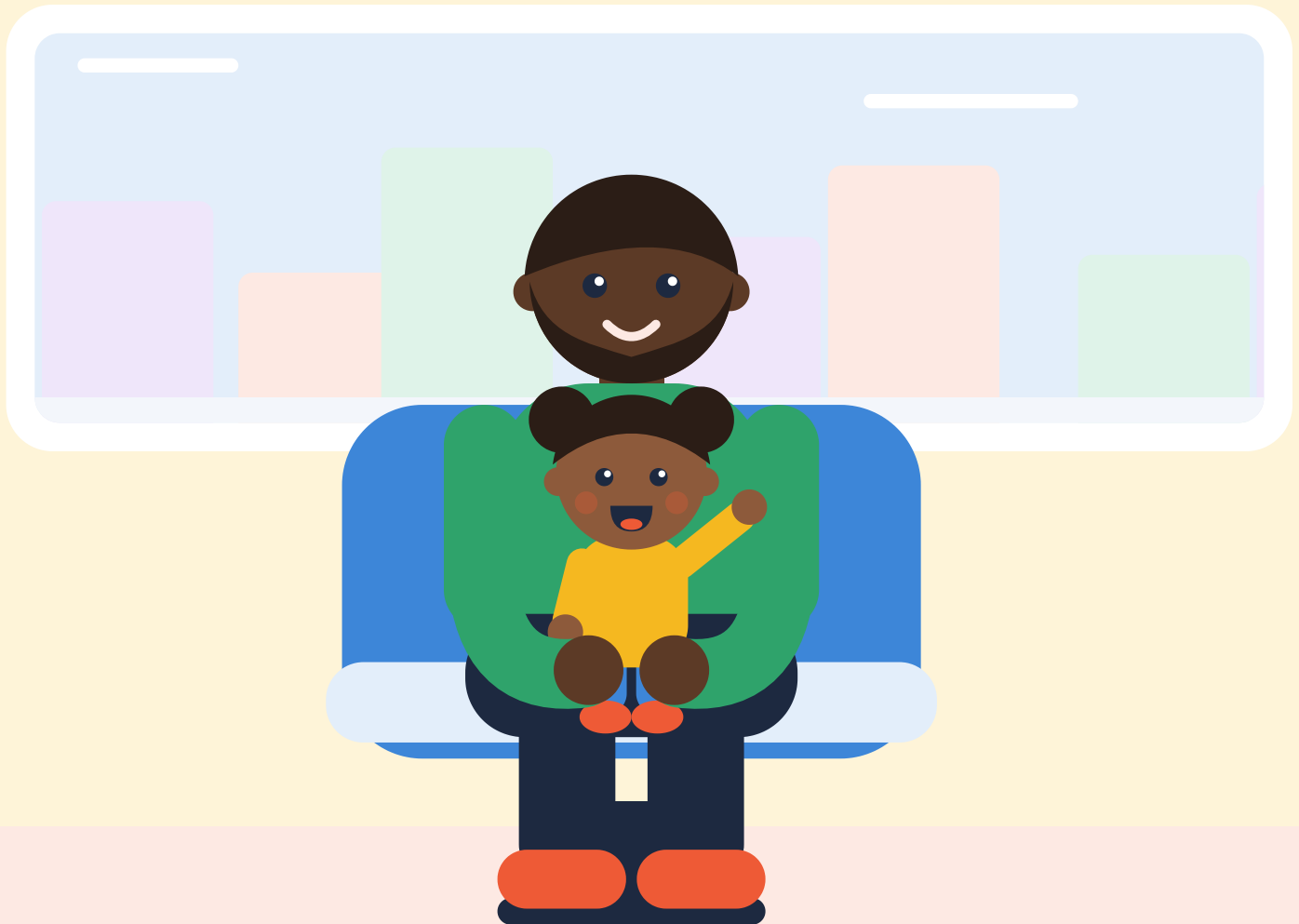
I turn all the pages.
I point and I name.
“Again!” And she reads it
again, just the same.

Lap talk Read favorites again and again. Try a big voice, a tiny voice,
a whisper—and let them pick.

Again!

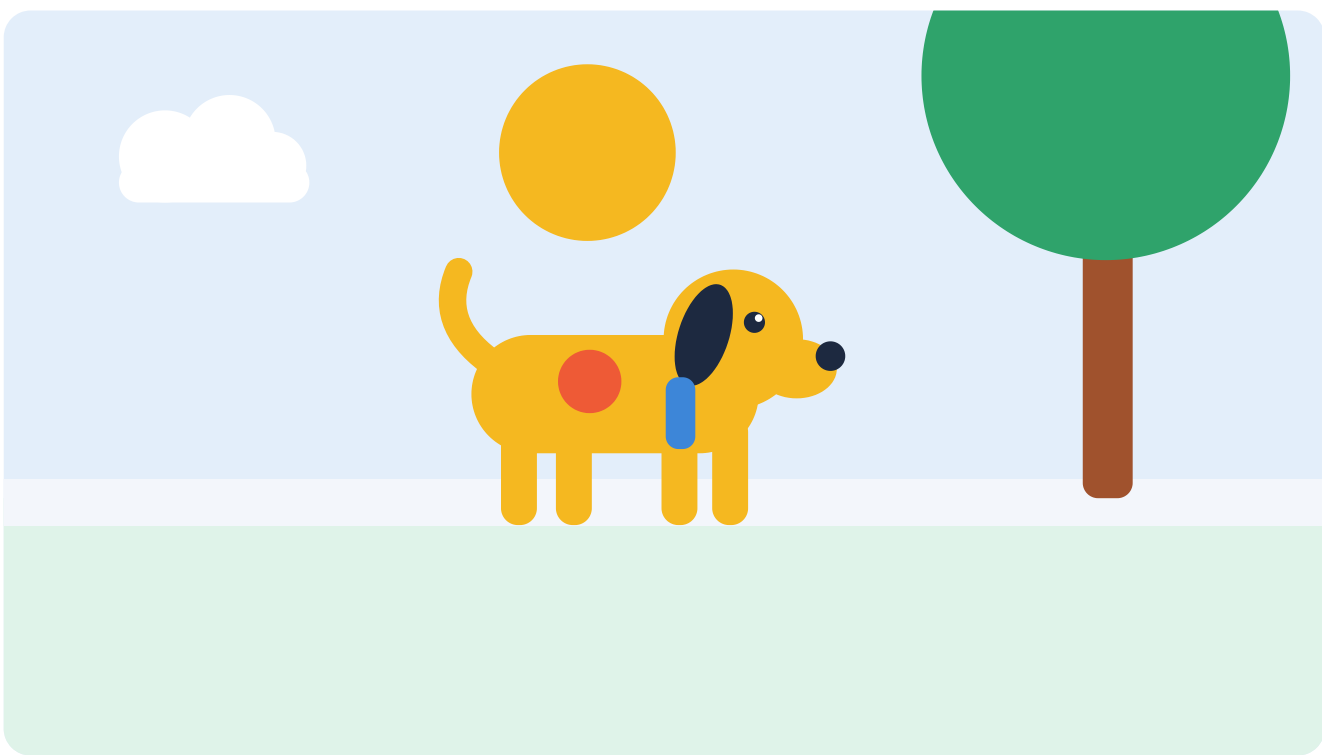


**We ride on the bus,
and the bus seat is high,
but Dad's lap is higher—
I'm up in the sky!**



“A dog!” I point out.
“A BIG dog!” Dad agrees.
“A big dog,” I tell him,
“who’s sniffing the trees!”

Lap talk Say what you see, then add one word: “dog” ... “big dog” ...
“big dog sniffing.”



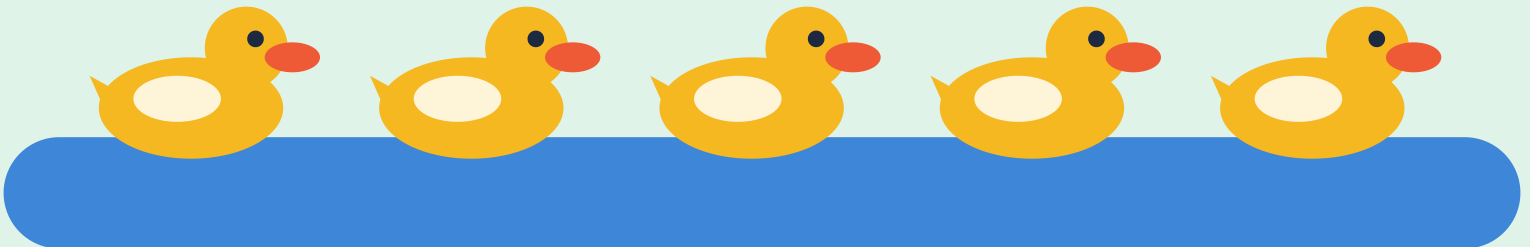
**My brother sits cross-legged—
a nest on the rug.
I plop in the middle.
He gives me a hug.**



He sings me the song
about ducks in a row.
He stops before “QUACK!”—
“Your turn, **Maya**. Go!”

Lap talk Sing a song they know and stop just before a fun word.
Wait. Let them fill it in—any sound counts.

QUACK!



**We clap and we tap
and we boop on the nose.
We sing it too slow,
then as fast as it goes!**

clap!

tap!



boop!

I lean on his chest
and I feel his voice hum—
a rumble, a buzz,
like a soft, sleepy drum.

Lap talk Follow their lead: faster, slower, louder, softer. Copy their sounds back to them.

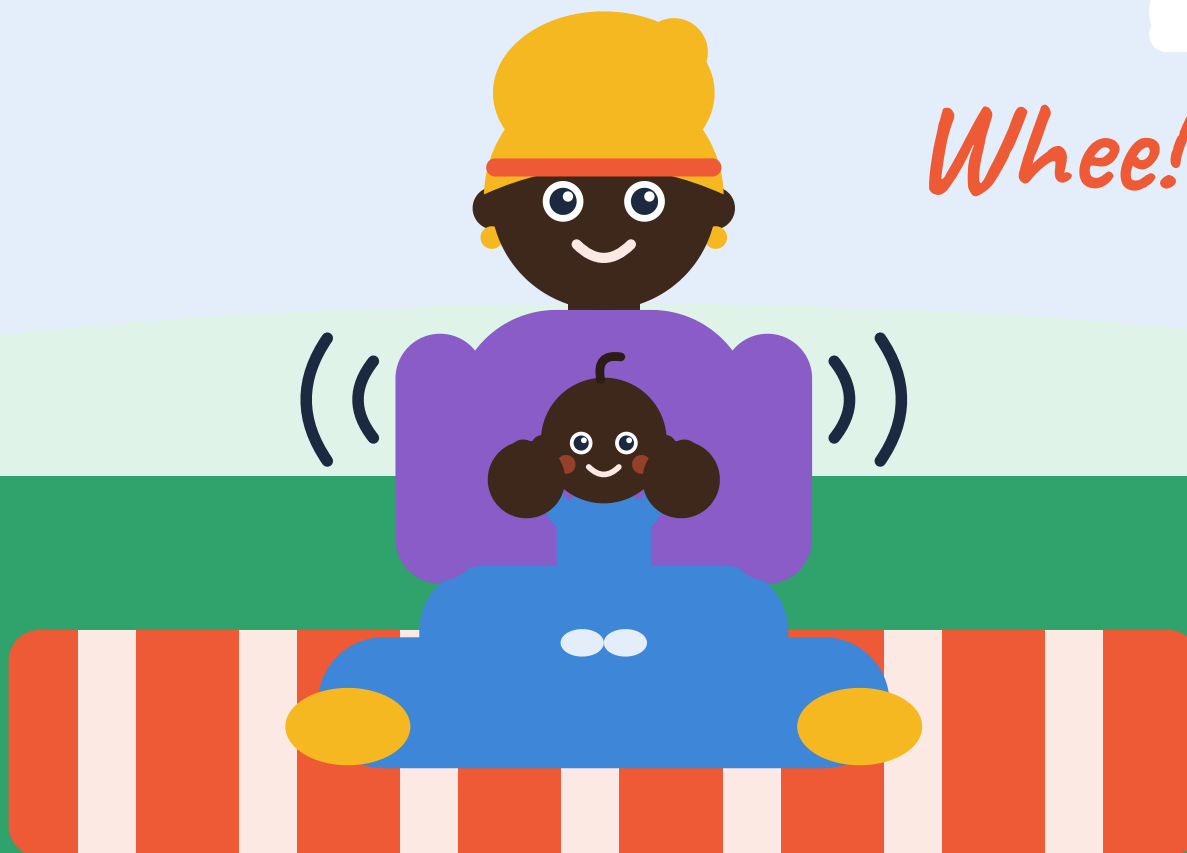


**At the park, on a blanket,
my friend Ada's there,
on Mama Jo's lap
with a flower in her hair.**

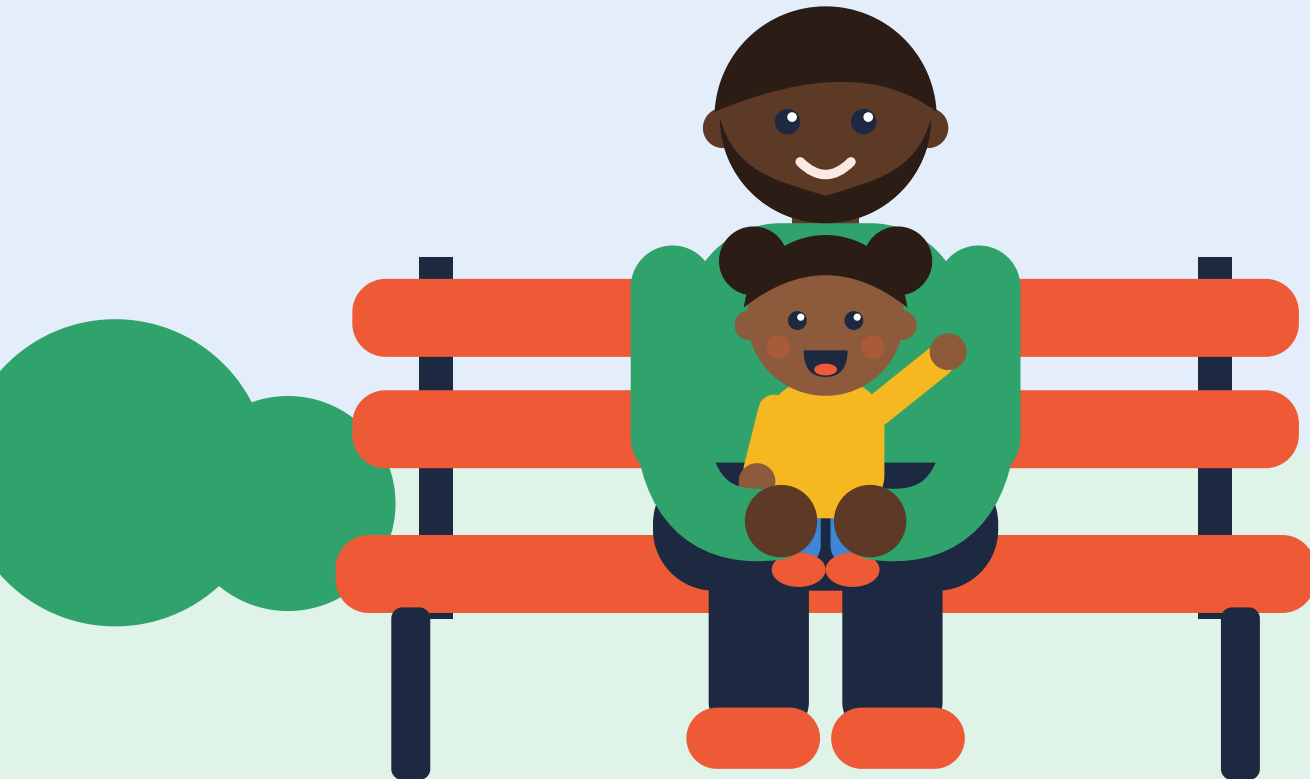


And Mama Bea's lap
is a pony—trot, trot!
The baby goes “Whee!”
and she giggles a lot.

Lap talk Offer a choice: “Slow pony or fast pony?” Then do exactly what they pick.

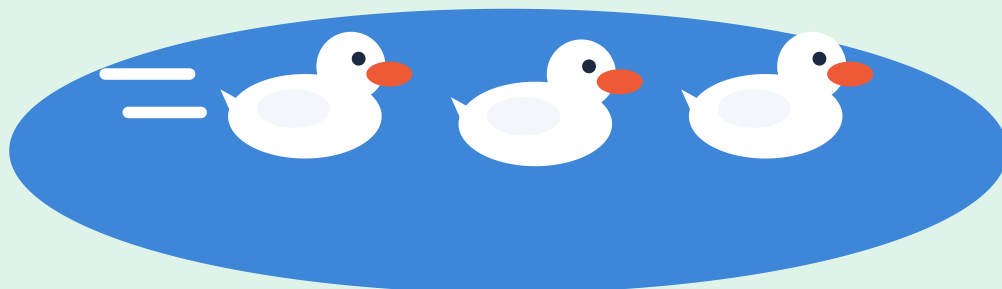


**We find a red bench
where the ducks paddle past.
We count them—one, two, three.
The last one is fast!**



Big laps and small laps
all out in the sun—
a park full of laps,
and a lap for each one!

Lap talk Count out loud together—ducks, dogs, buses, buttons.
Point to each one as you count.



**Back home, something's sitting
right smack in my place:
our cat, on Grandma's lap,
with a smug little face!**



“Make room for *Maya!*”
Grandma laughs. So we share:
one lap, and one cat,
and one kid, and one chair.

Lap talk Ask a “who” question and wait: “Who is on Grandma’s lap?” Pointing is a great answer too.



**When rain taps the window—
tip-tap, drip-drop—
we build a big fort
with a sheet on the top.**



We drape it from Grandma's
wheelchair to the couch,
and squeeze in together—
no room for a grouch!

Lap talk Name the feelings: cozy, snug, squished, silly. Ask, "How does it feel in here?"



The moon's in the window.
The sky's navy blue.
My eyes are all heavy.
My yawns are big, too.

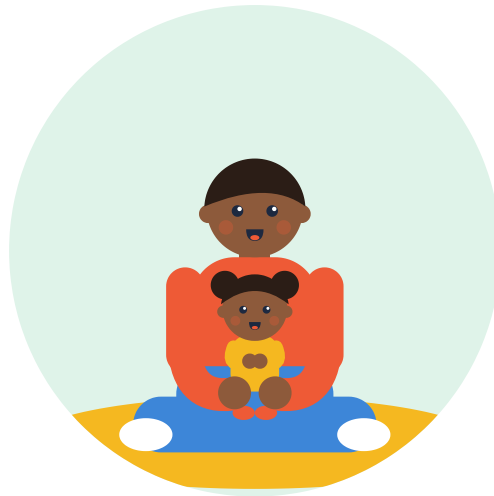


Dad rocks in the rocker,
so slow, to and fro.
“Goodnight, **Maya**,” he whispers,
and hums soft and low.

Lap talk The same quiet song every night can become your family’s
goodnight signal.



**There are laps on the bus.
There are laps on the ground.
There are laps that go rolling
and rocking around.**



But the best lap of all,
as the stars start to shine,
is right here, my **Maya**,
with your cheek next to mine.

Lap talk Ask, “Whose lap is best for stories?” Then tell them yours.



For grown-ups

5 lap games for tiny ones

No batteries, no screens—just you, a lap and a few silly minutes. Keep games short, stop while it's still fun, and let your little one ask for “more” in any way they can.

1

Pony Ride

Once your baby holds their head steady

Sit your little one on your knees, facing you, with a firm hold under the arms. Chant “Trot, trot, trot...” with small bounces. On “Whoa!”, stop—and wait for a look, a wiggle or a word that says “more.”

Safe play: Small, gentle bounces only. Never shake, toss or drop a baby.

2

Row the Boat

Babies who can sit, toddlers, big kids

Face to face, hold hands or forearms and rock slowly forward and back while you sing a rowing song. Stop the boat mid-song. Wait for them to rock you to start again.

Safe play: Rock slowly. Never pull, swing or lift a child by the hands or arms.

3

Peekaboo Lap

From the early months

Cover your own face with your hands or a light cloth. “Where did I go?” Pause... “Peekaboo!” Soon they will pull the cloth away themselves.

Safe play: Cover your face, not theirs. Put the cloth away afterward—never leave one with a sleeping baby.

4

Toe Count

All ages

Hold a foot and count the toes: “One, two, three, four...” Stop before “FIVE!” and wait for a squeal, a wiggle or a word. Then do fingers.

Safe play: Gentle touches. If they pull away, that’s a “no”—switch games.

5

Lap Drum

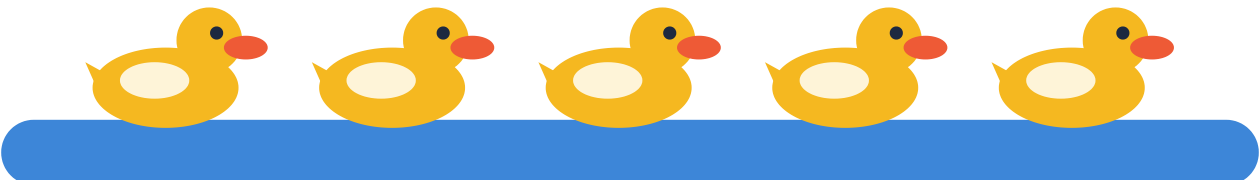
Toddlers and up

Pat a beat on your knees—slow, fast, soft, loud. They copy you. Then swap: they lead and you copy them. A sturdy board book makes a great drum.

Safe play: Hands and board books only. For under-3s, nothing small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube.

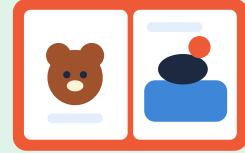
Lap-time safety

- An adult stays close and hands-on for every game.
- For children under 3: no objects small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm), no balloons, and no cords or strings long enough to wrap a neck.
- In a car, children ride in a properly installed car seat—never on a lap. On buses and trains, follow local rules and hold on securely.
- Sleepy snuggles are lovely. When a baby falls asleep, move them to their own safe sleep space, on their back.
- Stop any game when your child looks away, fusses or says “no.”



Our family reading pledge

Books before screens



For **Maya, we promise to:**

- ☐ read together every day, even for five minutes
- ☐ let **Maya** choose the book (again and again)
- ☐ rest our phones face-down at story time
- ☐ pause and wait, so she can take a turn—any way counts
- ☐ reach for a book, a song or a lap before a screen
- ☐ our own promise: _____

Signed, the grown-ups

Maya's mark (a scribble counts!)

Date



Play Before Pixels

Snap your signed pledge and share it with **#PlayBeforePixels**, if you like.

How to use this book

A lap is a small place with a big job.



When **Maya** is close enough to feel your voice, reading turns into a conversation. You say something, you pause, and you wait for her turn—a look, a point, a sound, a word. Every spread has a **Lap talk** idea to help that back-and-forth along.

There is no right way to read this book. Skip pages. Make up voices. Read the same page ten times. The goal isn't finishing—it's the talking along the way. Let your phone rest face-down for a few minutes. Your little one will notice.

Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. A point, a sign, a sound or a tap on a talking device counts too. Some children would rather sit beside you than on your lap; beside counts just as much.

Maya's favorite laps

Best lap for stories _____

Best lap for songs _____

Best lap for sleepy time _____

Our first read together _____



More from Play Before Pixels

Next for your little one's age



Up! Go! More!

Talk-along book · ages 0–3



100 Screen-Free Plays for Ages 0–5

Guide + printables · ages 0–5



The Day the Tablet Slept

Picture book · ages 3–7



Free for grown-ups

A printable lap-reading tracker and 5 more lap games.

playbeforepixels.com/bonus/picture-laps-not-apps

We ask only for an email and your child's birth month and year—never a name.



Play Before Pixels

A lap is the best seat in town.

A lap for a story. A lap on the bus. A lap for a song, a lap at the park, and a sleepy lap when the moon comes up. In this rhyming read-aloud, the grown-ups who love **Maya** call her by name to the best seats in town.

- Rhyming read-aloud with the child's name in six rhymes
- A “Lap talk” idea on every spread for grown-ups
- Dedication, family reading pledge and keepsake pages



Collect the books

-  Laps Not Apps
-  The Day the Tablet Slept
-  Up! Go! More!